

UNDERSTANDING ANXIETY

An Educator's Workshop
for Teaching Students



Understand



Empathize



Empower

Knowledge. Skills. Confidence.
Helping students thrive.

Workshop Overview

Goals

Help students understand what anxiety is.

Normalize anxiety and reduce stigma.

Teach practical strategies to manage anxiety.

Promote empathy and supportive classroom culture.

Overview

This workshop gives students a clear understanding of anxiety and introduces evidence-based strategies they can use in real life.

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WHAT IS ANXIETY?

Anxiety is the body's natural response to stress or danger.



Short-term anxiety can help keep us safe.

Long-term or intense anxiety can make it hard to focus, learn, or enjoy everyday life.



Signs & Effects



Body

**Racing heart, stomachaches,
headaches, muscle tension**



Thoughts

**Worrying, negative self-talk, racing
thoughts, overthinking**



Feelings

**Nervousness, fear, irritability,
sadness, feeling overwhelmed**



Behavior

**Avoiding situations, trouble
concentrating, restlessness**



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The STOP Technique

A simple strategy to pause and regain control.

S

S — Stop

Pause what you are doing.

T

T — Take a Breath

Breathe in slowly. Breathe out slowly.

O

O — Observe

Notice your thoughts, feelings, and body.

P

P — Proceed

Choose what's helpful and take the next step.

Practice makes progress. You've got this!



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Causes & Triggers

Everyone is different, but common triggers can include:

- **School or academic pressure**
- **Social situations**
- **Changes or uncertainty**
- **Family or relationships**
- **Big life events**
- **Perfectionism**
- **Negative self-talk**

What are some of your triggers?



Managing Anxiety

Strategies that can
help:

- **Deep breathing**
- **Positive self-talk**
- **Physical activity**
- **Healthy sleep**
- **Journaling**
- **Talking to someone**
- **Mindfulness**

Small steps can lead to big changes.



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Discussion Questions

Use these questions to spark meaningful conversations.

1 What does anxiety feel like for you?

2 What are things that trigger your anxiety?

3 How does anxiety affect your thoughts, feelings, and actions

4 What strategies help you feel better when you're anxious?

5 How can we support each other in our classroom?



Student Handout:

The STOP Technique

S**S — Stop****Pause what you are doing.****T****T — Take a Breath****Breathe in slowly. Breathe out slowly.****O****O — Observe****Notice your thoughts, feelings, and body.****P****P — Proceed****Choose what's helpful and take the next step.**

I can pause. I can breathe. I can choose. I can handle this.



Teacher Notes & Extension Ideas

Teacher Notes

Create a safe and inclusive space.

Validate student experiences.

Encourage participation without pressure.

Extension Ideas

- Mindfulness activity
- Gratitude journaling
- Classroom calming toolkit
- Peer support projects

Together, we can build resilient minds and compassionate communities.

